IT Acceptable Use Policy

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1. Purpose

This policy establishes the rules governing the acceptable use of company-owned computing equipment, networks, and information systems by all employees, contractors, and temporary staff of Meridian Holdings Group ("the Company"). Its purpose is to protect the Company's information assets from unauthorised access, misuse, or loss, while enabling staff to use IT resources efficiently in support of their duties.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all individuals who are granted access to Company IT resources, including desktop computers, laptops, mobile devices, email accounts, internal networks, cloud storage systems, and any third-party software licensed to the Company. It covers use of these resources both on Company premises and remotely.

3. General Principles

3.1 Company IT resources are provided primarily for business purposes. Limited personal use is permitted provided it does not interfere with an employee's duties, does not consume significant network bandwidth or storage, and does not violate any other provision of this policy.

3.2 Employees must not use Company IT resources to access, store, or distribute material that is illegal, discriminatory, defamatory, or sexually explicit.

3.3 All passwords must comply with the Company's Password Standard (minimum twelve characters, including at least one uppercase letter, one number, and one symbol) and must not be shared with any other individual, including colleagues and IT support staff.

3.4 Employees must lock their workstation whenever they leave it unattended, even for short periods.

4. Email and Communication

4.1 Company email accounts must not be used to send confidential information to external parties without prior authorisation from the employee's line manager and, where the information is classified as Restricted, from the Data Protection Officer.

4.2 Employees must exercise caution with unsolicited emails and attachments and must report suspected phishing attempts to the IT Service Desk immediately, without opening any linked attachments.

5. Software and Hardware

5.1 Only software approved by the IT Department may be installed on Company devices. Requests for new software must be submitted through the IT Service Portal.

5.2 Employees must not attempt to disable, bypass, or uninstall antivirus software, firewalls, or other security controls installed on Company devices.

5.3 Any loss or theft of a Company device must be reported to the IT Service Desk and to the employee's line manager within twenty-four hours of discovery.

6. Remote Access

6.1 Remote access to Company systems is permitted only through the Company's approved Virtual Private Network (VPN) client. Use of personal, unmanaged devices to access Company email or internal systems is prohibited unless the device has been enrolled in the Company's Mobile Device Management (MDM) programme.

6.2 Employees working remotely must ensure that their home network is secured with a password and that Company devices are not used on unsecured public Wi-Fi networks without VPN protection.

7. Monitoring

7.1 The Company reserves the right to monitor use of its IT resources, including email traffic and internet browsing activity, for the purposes of ensuring compliance with this policy, protecting the Company's systems, and meeting legal and regulatory obligations. Monitoring will be conducted in accordance with the Company's Data Protection Policy and applicable law.

8. Non-Compliance

8.1 Breach of this policy may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment, and may, in serious cases, be reported to law enforcement authorities.

9. Related Documents

- Password Standard (IT-STD-04)
- Data Protection Policy (LEGAL-POL-02)
- Mobile Device Management Guidelines (IT-GDL-07)

10. Approval

This policy was approved by the IT Steering Committee on 15 February 2026 and supersedes version 3.1, dated 10 September 2024.